CONNECT DAILY

Friday 30 October 2026
themapsproject.com

A daily scan of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear "so what for your school" line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, get in touch.

TOP LINE

- Today is payment day for the 2026 Schools Budget Support Grant - about £635m nationally going out to local authorities - but it's a continuation of existing cost-pressure funding, not new Budget money.
- DfE still hasn't published its own breakdown of Wednesday's Budget settlement, so keep treating school-funding figures doing the rounds - including on the SEND gap - as provisional.
- Today is the final day of Sheffield schools' autumn half term; pupils return Monday 2 November - check individual academy calendars rather than assuming a uniform city-wide date.
- Reminder: the NEU's formal strike ballot over pay, funding and workload is still open and closes 15 December.

DATES FOR THE DIARY

26-30 Oct 2026 — Sheffield schools' autumn half term - today is the final day.

30 Oct 2026 — First Schools Budget Support Grant 2026 payments go out to local authorities.

2 Nov 2026 — Sheffield schools return from half term.

15 Dec 2026 — NEU's formal strike ballot over pay, funding and workload closes.

Early 2027 — UK City of Culture 2029 winner announced; Sheffield is one of four finalists.

NATIONAL POLICY & FUNDING

▪ **First SBSG 2026 payments land today.** DfE is distributing roughly £635m nationally this financial year through the Schools Budget Support Grant 2026, covering centrally employed local-authority staff plus early years and post-16 provision; the first tranche reaches local authorities today, with academies paid in November. It's a continuation of existing cost-pressure support rather than new Budget money - the mainstream-schools element has already been folded into the national funding formula for 2026-27. (GOV.UK - Department for Education)

→ **For your school:** *Check your local authority's payment schedule if you're relying on this grant for centrally-employed-staff costs this term.*

▪ **Budget breakdown still pending.** Two days on from Chancellor John Healey's Budget, DfE has yet to publish its own schools-funding breakdown of the settlement. Keep holding off on budget-planning assumptions, including on the scale of the SEND funding gap, until that lands. (Tes)

SHEFFIELD & SOUTH YORKSHIRE

▪ **Half term's last day.** Today is the final day of Sheffield's autumn half term before pupils return on Monday 2 November. Academies can set their own calendar, so it's worth checking individual school dates rather than assuming a uniform city-wide return. (Sheffield City Council (via SaveMyExams term dates))

DATA POINT OF THE WEEK

£635m

DfE's Schools Budget Support Grant for 2026-27, covering centrally employed staff, early years and post-16 provision - first local-authority payments go out today.

DfE, Schools Budget Support Grant 2026 methodology

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. Explore School+

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; “Who’s Losing Learning?”
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Daily is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.